Vance had indeed highlighted to Huang the denial of the Viggen to India to counter intensifying Chinese complaints about "slow and scanty" military aid to Pakistan.[184] Washington was getting more responsive to these Chinese calls, both because they came in the midst of normalization talks and because the situation in Afghanistan and Pakistan was deteriorating. Through most of 1977 and the first half of 1978, even as India-Pakistan relations had improved somewhat, US-Pakistan relations had been "essentially frozen," as Thornton put it.[185] This was for a series of reasons: Bhutto's anti-American turn, General Muhammad Zia-ul-Haq's military coup, the arrest and sentencing to death of Bhutto, and Pakistani attempts to acquire nuclear enrichment and reprocessing facilities. But the coup in Afghanistan and growing Soviet influence there had caused a rethink in Washington. This resulted in renewed arms sales to Pakistan, as well as Brzezinski considering cutting economic assistance for India because more was needed for Pakistan and other countries for geopolitical reasons.[186] The military aid, including the provision of F-5 aircraft, particularly caused chagrin in India. More broadly, Desai worried about Moscow and Washington returning to Cold War language and framing.[187]

As 1978 drew to a close, the US embassy in Delhi identified three factors complicating what was an "overall positive and cooperative" US-India relationship. These were the situation in Afghanistan, the lack of progress on nuclear issues, and the "lackluster performance" of the Desai government at home. Among its goals for 1979 was encouraging an improvement in Sino-Indian relations.[188] This had been put on hold with the last-minute postponement of Vajpayee's trip to China—the reason given was medical advice, but there was also speculation that instability within the JP was the real cause.[189] China made clear that whenever the foreign minister could visit, it would be willing to discuss all open issues. The State Department believed this signified Beijing's desire to keep the process moving and "to upstage the Soviets."[190] As for India, the US believed that Desai had to move gingerly because of anti-China sentiments within the JP.[191]

New Openings

On the US end, there was substantial movement with China. In mid-December, Carter announced that the US was normalizing relations with